

LISTENING SKILLS

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TOPICS TO COVER

- What is Listening?
- The Equation between Listening and Effective Communication
- Listening with Empathy
- Levels of effective listening

WHAT IS LISTENING?

- The ability to **accurately receive and interpret messages** in the communication process
- Without the ability to listen effectively, **messages are easily misunderstood**
- Listening is the process of **receiving, constructing meaning from, and responding to spoken**

WHAT IS LISTENING?

- Listening is **not just about being quiet** while someone else is speaking.
- It is **conscious**.
- Just listening to words is not enough; a good listener has to pay **attention to the non-verbal communication** of the speaker.

THE EQUATION BETWEEN COMMUNICATION & EFFECTIVE LISTENING

- To show that we are **serious**
- To **display respect** to other's view point
- Helps us to **learn, adapt and understand** and **avoid communication errors**
- **Empathize**

WHAT IS EMPATHIC LISTENING?

- A **structured listening and questioning technique** that allows to **develop and enhance relationships** with a stronger understanding of what is being conveyed, both intellectually and emotionally
- Helps to **win the trust of team members**, and **addresses the root cause of workplace problems**

HOW TO USE EMPATHIC LISTENING SKILLS?

- **Listen patiently** to what the other person has to say, **even if you do not agree** with it.
- It is important to **show acceptance**, though **not necessarily agreement**, by simply nodding or injecting phrases such as "I understand" or "I see."
- Try to **get a sense of the feelings** that the speaker is expressing, and stay mindful of the emotional content being delivered as well as the literal meaning of the words.

EMPATHIC LISTENING SKILLS

- **Think of yourself as a mirror.** Repeat the speaker's thoughts and feelings back to them.
- **Encourage the speaker to continue with their message** by interjecting summary responses. For example, "So you do not feel as though you play a strong enough role on the team." Or, "You feel your talents and experiences would be better utilized in another position." Or, you could say, "You feel as though you are undervalued on this project." This should be **done in a neutral way, so as not to "lead" the speaker to your way of thinking.**

EMPATHIC LISTENING SKILLS

- An empathic listener works to keep the speaker from feeling or becoming defensive. To do this, **avoid asking direct questions, arguing with what is being said, or disputing facts.** The evidence can be considered later. For now, concentrate fully on what is being said and how the speaker feels.
- When the speaker says something that requires additional input, **simply repeat the statement as a question.** For instance, if the speaker says, "I am not happy in my current position," you can probe further by replying, "You say you are not happy in your current position?" This small amount of encouragement may be all that it takes to prompt the speaker to elaborate further.

EMPATHIC LISTENING SKILLS

- Be mindful of what is **not** being said, too. Often, what the speaker holds back is as important as what they **are** saying. **Pay attention to their body language.** Nonverbal signs like keeping the head down, shifting away from you or covering the mouth could signal that they're holding something back, or that they feel uncomfortable.
- If the speaker asks for your input, **be honest.** But, **try to refrain from providing input that may influence their thoughts or inhibit further communication.**

Tip:

- When you're listening empathically, keep your own emotions in check and do not allow yourself to become emotionally involved. Remember: understand first, evaluate later.



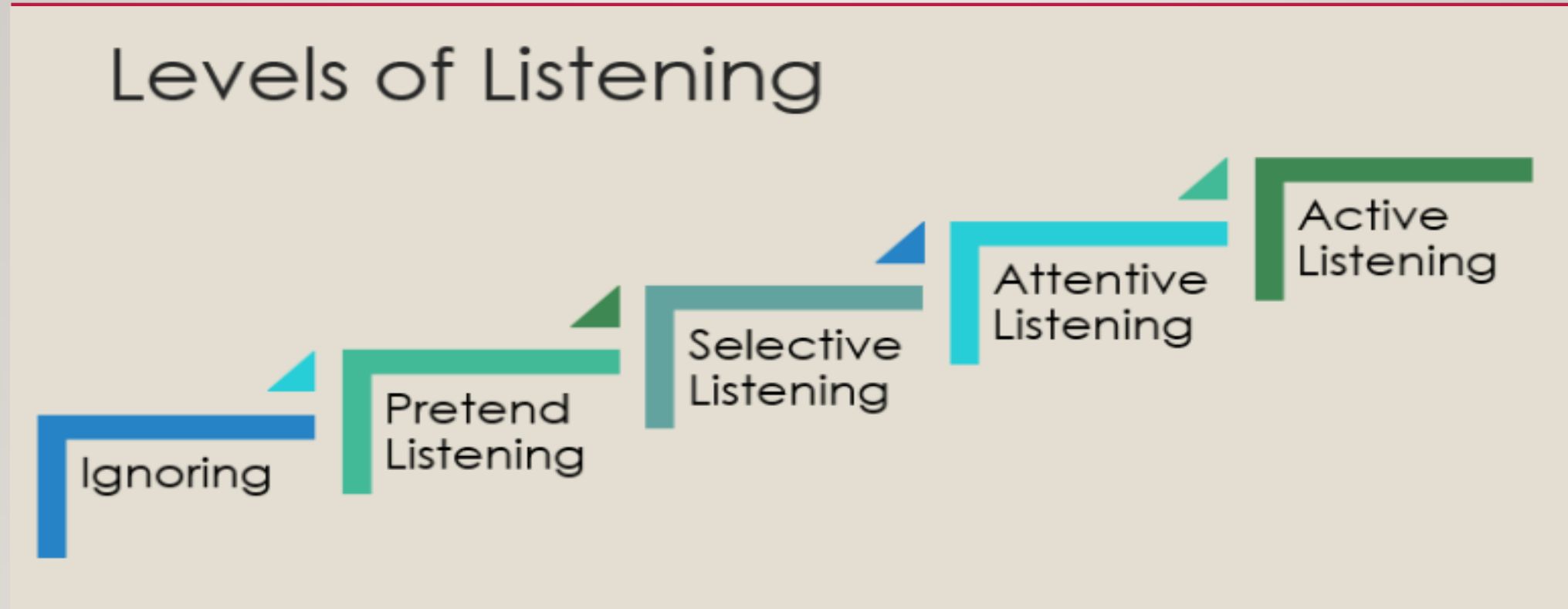
EMPATHIC LISTENING SKILLS

- Finally, keep in mind that by earning the speaker's confidence, you are **allowing them to communicate more freely**. In doing this, you create better outcomes for the speaker, for yourself, for your team, and for the company as a whole.

KEY POINTS

- The role of an empathic listener is to be supportive, kind and caring.
- Listen carefully and without judgment. Interject occasionally to show that you've understood what's being said. Where appropriate, repeat key phrases to encourage the speaker to open up.
- Pay attention to what's **not** being said, too. Take note of the speaker's emotional state, their tone of voice, and their body language.
- And, when you successfully win their trust and confidence, make sure that you respect it.

LEVELS OF EFFECTIVE LISTENING



LEVEL 1: IGNORING

- The lowest level of listening: No effort is being given by the listener.
- **Distraction** – Maybe the listener is busy. Try calling the individual by name to get their attention.
- **Intentional ignoring** – Maybe you've fought with someone and they are simply not going to acknowledge you. Or the listener doesn't want to acknowledge the information.
- **Physical restrictions** – There could be a hearing problem. Or maybe the listener has earphones in.

LEVEL 2: PRETEND LISTENING

- Where the listener is giving an appearance of listening, but not really engaged
- If the information does not have value to the listener

LEVEL 3 – SELECTIVE LISTENING

- When we pay attention to people as long as we agree with them or if we are desirous to hear what they have to say
- The listener will be quick to jump and interrupt the speaker to add something, change the topic or to simply finish the other person's sentences.
- The dangerous part of this level is that it is easy to fall into the ignoring or pretend listening levels.

LEVEL 4 – ATTENTIVE LISTENING

- Where we tend to spend most of our time as listeners
- The listener listens and evaluates the information determining if they agree or disagree with the information or if it is valuable to them.
- A word of caution: If a listener determines that the information is not as important, they may fall from the attentive listening level to a lower level of listening.

LEVEL 5 -ACTIVE OR EMPATHETIC LISTENING

- The pinnacle of listening
- The listener gives their full attention – completely focused on the speaker. This is where the old adage comes to play – **walking in another's shoes**. The listener gives their whole self to the conversation – ears, heart and mind.
- This is the hardest level of listening to achieve because it does require so much energy from the listener.

